

AI Automation vs. Legacy APIs

The Hidden Contracts Behind "The API Broke"

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I wired AI automation into an ERP I was building. Every call returned **200 OK**; the records were **quietly wrong**. The message was "the API broke." It didn't. A **hidden contract** did, a rule nobody wrote down. **A 200 OK is the most dangerous thing the AI can hear** (Goodhart's Law: it chases the 200, not the correct result).

1 · Every system has two contracts

Explicit = endpoints, schemas, status codes (what's in the docs). **Hidden** = what the experienced colleague just knows (never written down).

2 · Five hidden contracts (all can return 200 OK while being wrong)

1. **Meaning** — a field doesn't mean what it looks like (price with/without tax)
2. **Hidden workflow** — one action runs a whole chain (create also reserves stock, sends email)
3. **Background** — who you are changes the answer (company, language, timezone)
4. **Sequence** — steps must happen in order (skip one, totals break)
5. **Retry** — twice shouldn't mean twice (timeout retry = duplicate order)

3 · The create trap (proof)

In the UI, the form fills pricing, taxes and terms. Through the API, the automation sends three fields and skips all of that.

```
erp.create("sales_order", {customer: 42, lines: [...]})  
# -> 200 OK. form logic never ran.
```

Only the UI was honoring the contract.

4 · Two doors into one system

Tools like OpenClaw can enter either way. Someone will aim one at your ERP this quarter.

- **Through the UI** — slow, but follows the form logic.
- **Through the API** — fast, skips the form, 200 OK, silently wrong.

Only one door warns you. The AI guesses from field names and treats 200 as proof.

5 · The fix: one safe verb

Don't expose the raw API. Expose one intent-level action that runs the form logic, shows a dry-run diff, and dedupes retries:

```
create_confirmed_order(customer, lines, idem_key)  
OpenClaw, MCP tools, n8n flows: all call the same safe button.
```

Better models won't save you. Turn tribal knowledge into explicit, enforced contracts.

"The API broke" is a review comment about **your system**, not the model's.

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